Archives and Archival Resources

H 1230

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A. Background

Archives are collections of documents or records relating to the activities, business dealings, etc., of a person, family, corporation, association, community, or nation. This instruction sheet provides guidelines for assigning the subdivisions ***--Archives*** and ***--Archival resources***. For guidelines on classification of archival inventories, see F 495, sec. 1-2. For guidelines on classification of works on archival resources, see F 630.

LC practice: As stated in H 1075, LC catalogers will no longer use form subdivisions. Instead assign an appropriate term or terms from Library of Congress Genre/Form Terms (LCGFT), e.g. ***Catalogs***. To replace a form subdivision that includes a demographic group, also assign Library of Congress Demographic Groups Terms (LCDGT) to bring out the audience of the resource being cataloged, e.g. ***German speakers*** or ***Arabic, Students of***.

B. Recent revisions

2026-07: Updated template. Added instructions related to LCGFT implementation.

C. Definitions

Archives: documentary material, such as records, manuscripts, household records, diaries, correspondence, photographs, memorabilia, etc. pertaining to an agent or a topic.

D. Archives

D.1. General

Use the free-floating subdivision ***--Archives*** as a form or topical subdivision under types of corporate bodies and educational institutions, classes of persons, and ethnic groups, and under names of individual corporate bodies, military services, educational institutions, persons, and families, for collections of documentary material, such as manuscripts, household records, diaries, correspondence, photographs, memorabilia, etc., pertaining to these persons or institutions. Use the topical subdivision for discussions of such collections.

Assign an array of headings to bring out both the archive and the subject matter of the documents it contains.

LC practice: For discussions of documentary material, assign a subject heading with the topical subdivision ***--Archives*** under types of corporate bodies and educational institutions, classes of persons, and ethnic groups, and under names of individual corporate bodies, military services, educational institutions, persons, and families. For collections of documentary material, such as manuscripts, household records, diaries, correspondence, photographs, memorabilia, etc., assign subject headings to reflect the topical focus of the documentary materials, including the relevant agents that created or collected the materials. Also assign LCGFT appropriate to the form and/or genre of the resource in hand, e.g. LCGFT ***Records (Documents)***.

Examples:

Title: The personal archives of President Calvin Coolidge.[1]

600 10 $a Coolidge, Calvin, $d 1872-1933 $v Archives.

651 #0 $a United States $x Politics and government $y 1923-1929 $v Sources.

LC practice:

600 10 $a Coolidge, Calvin, $d 1872-1933.

651 #0 $a United States $x Politics and government $y 1923-1929.

655 #7 $a Records (Documents) $2 lcgft

655 #7 $a Business correspondence. $2 lcgft

655 #7 $a Personal correspondence. $2 lcgft

[1] About this Collection | Calvin Coolidge Papers | Digital Collections | Library of Congress

Title: Documents of the State Department relating to the history of Greece from 1950 to 1954.

651 #0 $a Greece $x History $y 1950-1967 $v Sources.

610 10 $a United States. $b Dept. of State $v Archives.

LC practice:

651 #0 $a Greece $x History $y 1950-1967.

610 10 $a United States. $b Dept. of State.

655 #7 $a Records (Documents) $2 lcgft

Title: Papers of the Society of American Indians [microform]

650 #0 $a Indigenous peoples $z North America $x History $v Sources.

610 20 $a Society of American Indians $v Archives.

LC practice:

650 #0 $a Indigenous peoples $z North America $x History.

610 20 $a Society of American Indians.

655 #7 $a Records (Documents) $2 lcgft

655 #7 $a Ephemera. $2 lcgft

655 #7 $a Business correspondence. $2 lcgft

D.2. Individual corporate bodies

Use the free-floating subdivision ***--Archives*** under names of corporate bodies, including individual educational institutions, provided that the corporate body or educational institution prepares the archive for public access, and is not merely the institution that houses the archive. If the collection is a formally organized archive for which a name heading can be established, use that heading, as appropriate, instead of the subdivision ***--Archives*** under the name of the corporate body.

LC practice: For corporate bodies, including individual educational institutions, that prepare the archive for public access, not merely the institution that houses the archive, assign a subject heading for the body. If the collection is a formally organized archive for which a name heading can be established, use that heading instead. Also assign LCGFT appropriate to the form and/or genre of the resource in hand, e.g. LCGFT ***Records (Documents)***.

D.3. Catalogs

Use the free-floating form subdivision ***--Catalogs*** under the topical subdivision ***--Archives*** for inventories of documents and materials housed in an individual archive. In accordance with

H 1361, assign an array of headings to bring out the topics covered in the archives and the institution housing the material.

LC practice: For any inventory of documents and materials housed in an individual archive, assign subject headings in accordance with H 1361. Also assign LCGFT appropriate to the form and/or genre of the resource in hand, e.g. LCGFT ***Catalogs*.**

Examples:

Title: A catalog of the Southern Africa archives in the University of York.

651 #0 $a Africa, Southern $x History $x Sources $v Bibliography $v Catalogs.

651 #0 $a Africa, Southern $x History $x Manuscripts $v Catalogs.

610 20 $a University of York. $b Centre for Southern African Studies $x Archives $v Catalogs.

LC practice:

651 #0 $a Africa, Southern $x History $x Sources.

651 #0 $a Africa, Southern $x History $x Manuscripts.

610 20 $a University of York. $b Centre for Southern African Studies $x Archives.

655 #7 $a Bibliographies. $2 lcgft

655 #7 $a Catalogs. $2 lcgft

Title: Documents of the Royal Victoria Hospital held in the McGill University Archives.

610 20 $a Royal Victoria Hospital (Montréal, Québec) $x Archives $v Catalogs.

610 20 $a Royal Victoria Hospital (Montréal, Québec) $x History $x Sources $v Bibliography $v Catalogs.

610 20 $a McGill University. $b Archives $v Catalogs.

LC practice:

610 20 $a Royal Victoria Hospital (Montréal, Québec) $x Archives.

610 20 $a Royal Victoria Hospital (Montréal, Québec) $x History $x Sources.

610 20 $a McGill University. $b Archives.

655 #7 $a Bibliographies. $2 lcgft

655 #7 $a Catalogs. $2 lcgft

E. Archival resources

E.1. General

Use the free-floating topical subdivision ***--Archival resources*** under topical headings and names of countries, cities, etc., for brief descriptions of the types of documents and historical records about a particular topic or place available in an institution or institutions.

Do not use the subdivision ***--Archival resources*** for catalogs containing an item-by-item list of the holdings of an institution or institutions on a topic. See sec. D.3 above.

Note: ***--Archival resources*** was formerly further subdivided by place. That practice was discontinued in 1990. If the location of the resources is judged to be significant, bring it out by assigning the heading ***Archival resources--[place]*** as an additional heading.

Example:

```
Title: Christianity in China : a scholar's guide to resources in The
archives of the United States.
   650 #0 $a Christianity $z China $x Archival resources.
   651 #0 $a China $x Church history $x Archival resources.
   650 #0 $a Archival resources $z United States.
```

LC practice:

```
   No change in subject headings.
   655 #7 $a Collection catalogs. $2 lcgft
```

E.2. Directories

Use the free-floating form subdivision ***--Directories***, if appropriate, under headings of the type ***[topic or place]--Archival resources*** for works containing the names, addresses, and brief descriptions of institutions housing archival materials on a particular topic.

Example:

```
Title: Peace : archival and library collections in the United States.
   650 #0 $a Peace $x Archival resources $v Directories.
   650 #0 $a Peace $x Library resources $v Directories.
   650 #0 $a Archival resources $z United States $v Directories.
   650 #0 $a Library resources $z United States $v Directories.
```

LC practice:

```
   650 #0 $a Peace $x Archival resources.
   650 #0 $a Peace $x Library resources.
   650 #0 $a Archival resources $z United States.
```

```
650 #0 $a Library resources $z United States.
655 #7 $a Collection catalogs. $2 lcgft
655 #7 $a Directories. $2 lcgft
```

Revision history

2026-07: Updated template. Added instructions related to LCGFT implementation.